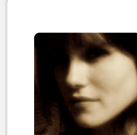


Embed a Tumblr Post

Language

Default

<div class="tumblr-post" data-href="https://embed.tumblr.com/embed/post/M4X6y6CkJQ2-4dfa0xYwg/181490071452" data-did="af33dd83e147c4808108a36b4793c9f810a70ee8">a href="https://abriegrowsinbrooklyn.com/post/181490071452/i-wish-i-had

briennewalsh

Open in tumblr

I Wish I Had Less

I think a lot of kids in America grow up dreaming about living in mansions. I was certainly one of those kids. When I was born, my parents lived in a one-bedroom apartment on Mosholu Parkway in the Bronx. When my sister was born, they moved to a two-bedroom on the Grand Concourse. My dad got a job in the back office of Drexel, a firm on Wall Street, and he bought a small house in the suburbs so that I could go to kindergarten at a good school. He quickly began making money, and traded that house in for a small Victorian a few blocks walk to my elementary school. By the time I was 13, he made a fortune, and we moved to a mansion on a road full of mansions, after spending almost a year looking at mansions throughout Westchester county.



From the second we moved into that house, none of us could sleep. There were 10 bedrooms, and they were too far apart. My sister almost always ended up in bed with me, as did my younger brother. If we didn't sleep together, we slept in my parents' room, where there was a queen sized bed and a small sofa. The weight of all of us in that small bed was enough that the boards holding it to its frame cracked in the middle of the night one night, wedging my father in a corner, and permanently fucking up his back.

This past week, I planned on staying in that house. There are a lot of hands living there, and I've just been beyond overwhelmed by myself with two children. At one point, last week, I was on my knees hysterically crying, and Cleo came up to me and said, "I miss Mommy." The guilt of being an imperfect human in front of her is unbearable. My mom planned day trips to the Bronx Zoo, the Norwalk aquarium, a trampoline fiesta. Cleo, I thought, would be happier.

But then, on Christmas Day, we arrived. Caleb says it's impossible to rest in the house, despite its size, because people are always walking around looking for snacks. That didn't bother me until I had to try to get my newborn to sleep, only to be continually thwarted by the sound of someone descending the main stairs, and running at full speed towards the snack cabinet.

I didn't realize how hormonal I still felt until my sister demanded that I take down a picture of her from my Instagram page, and I launched into a full blown screaming takedown of her narcissism. "What do you want, a halo light and A SHOT OF BOTOX?!" I screamed. That was the first time I threatened to leave immediately. I kept on threatening throughout the day, as the pressure of being away from our apartment mounted. When we had to wait for my dad to individually microwave each of our 11 plates before we could eat lunch. When my aunt sternly told me, "If you weren't coming for dinner, it would have been nice if you had texted me" while I breastfed an exhausted, and wide awake, Cass standing up at the sink, my nipples throbbing with the pain of being used to the brink of permanent damage. When Caleb was getting ready to head back to the city.

Caleb left; we tried to put down Cleo in her portable crib in my sister's room. My sister had won the dubious pleasure of sleeping with her after much wrangling with my other sister. Cleo, who had been through the same routine when I went to the hospital, completely freaked out. She looked up at me, and began saying, "Go home. Go home. Cleo home." I began crying for the 100th time that day. I made a decision. I was going to go back to our apartment. I called Caleb, who was audibly annoyed, and asked him to come pick us up. My dad helped me carry our 50 bags to the back door, where we all loaded them quickly in the car as soon as Caleb pulled up the driveway. Everyone was visibly relieved we were leaving.

Both Cleo and Cass screamed their fucking faces off for the first 40 minutes of the car ride back to Brooklyn, but I was so relieved to be going home that I just laughed through it.

The truth was, I was myself relieved not to sleep in that house. In a house that size, you don't need to share a room with anyone. The room that was mine there is roughly the size of our apartment. The closet is a walk-in closet. The house was built in 1781, so it's crumbling, but one would think, after living in such tight quarters in Brooklyn, that I would appreciate the space, at least. But I didn't. The bedroom was too far away from other people. It was so quiet. I wanted to see the lights on in all of my sibling's bedrooms. I wanted to hear them go about their routines before they went to bed — toothbrush, glass of water, toilet flush. I myself was without water, and to get any, I had to walk down two flights of stairs, which is roughly the same distance I have to walk in our current place to get a professionally made latte.

"I don't know how you live in such a big house," I told my family as I put on my shoes, and they ignored me. "It's stressful."

And it's true, it is stressful. If you bring something up to one of the bedrooms, you have to walk like 200 steps and three flights of stairs to get it back. If I place a glass of water in our bedroom at home, I just have to lie flat in the living room to knock it over with my finger.



Ever since the holidays, I've been feeling overwhelmed with stuff. I feel like I'm going to choke on it. I clean up our apartment all day, and it's still a mess. We've reached a critical mass here where we have too much — too many toys, too many clothes, too many gadgets, too much food. I know that this is a privileged complaint. But it is also a contemporary complaint. Things are so cheap now. Everything is built to be disposable. We throw out so much shit in America that China, which used to buy our recycling, has begun rejecting it, leaving us with even more shit. Cleo has 40 different toys, but never wants to play with any of them. I have a closet full of clothes, and only wear two outfits. I don't know if you feel like this, but it physically overwhelms me to live with so much waste. The suffocation is visceral. If only I had the time to throw it out all out ... which of course, I don't.

There are a lot of articles about how bad things are right now. Most recently, the New York Times published a piece about how modern parenting is so stressful. These articles are a dime a dozen, and basically point out how over scheduled and overattentive modern American parents are. This article was on the front page of the times on Christmas. Happy holidays, you motherfuckers who are trying too hard!

But there is of course nuance to this viewpoint. Yeah, parents are stressed. But I'm still waiting for the unhappiness to hit me. Because I'm happier than I've ever been. I have a daily purpose, which was completely lacking in my life when I was merely working in an office, or working as a freelance writer, to gain accolades and money. That felt so empty to me. And it was stressful to commute; to navigate co-working; to constantly worry about status and impressing other people. Parenting may be stressful, but it's also so joyful. I live in a 600 square foot apartment with my two children, but we all sleep so well here, close to each other. And yeah, I may be over scheduling them, but part of the reason why we do so many activities is because there are no societal or religious communities that we can rely on anymore. The state doesn't pay for childcare or child enrichment before the age of 4. And all of our morals come from for-profit companies like Facebook, instead of from churches, which by the way, are equally as corrupt and morally bankrupt. So yeah, we pay money not to be alone all day; to make friends; to see them. Give me communal childcare, and library that isn't a dimly lit broken computer game center, and I would not pay or schedule shit.

Anyway, this holiday was a hard one. I know it will get better. For now, I'm grateful for what I have, and wish I had lesser.

#My life #Motherhood

7 notes

... ↻ ❤